Overlays can be used to add features to Mozilla without contaminating the original open source code with proprietary alterations.

XPCOM/XPConnect

XPCOM and XPConnect are complementary technologies that enable the integration of external libraries with XUL applications. XPCOM, which stands for Cross Platform Component Object Model, is a framework for writing cross-platform, modular software. XPCOM components can be written in C, C++, and JavaScript, and can be used from C, C++, JavaScript, Python, Java and Perl.

XPConnect is a technology which enables simple interoperation between XPCOM and JavaScript. XPConnect allows JavaScript objects to transparently access and manipulate XPCOM objects. It also enables JavaScript objects to present XPCOM-compliant interfaces to be called by XPCOM objects.

Together, XPCOM and XPConnect enable developers to create XUL applications that require the raw processing power of compiled languages (C/C++) or access to the underlying operating system.

XPInstall

XPInstall, Mozilla's Cross Platform Install facility, provides a standard way of packaging XUL application components with an install script that Mozilla can download and execute.

XPInstall enables users to effortlessly install new XUL applications over the internet or from corporate intranet servers. To install a new application the user need only click a hypertext link on a web page or in an email message and accept the new package through a Mozilla install dialog.

While XUL was developed to aid the process of development at Mozilla, it has also been used beyond the realms of that single organisation, with many web apps, such as the Mozilla Amazon Browser, being developed in recent times. But, it has suffered due to the general indifference of the industry towards newer entrants in the technology, and also due to the distinct lack of standardisation. Now, armed with this extensive knowledge of XUL, let's try our hand at developing.